

Lead a StoryDogs Group

A one-page companion to Start Here • Teachers and librarians • K–6

Build one shared story in about 20 minutes. Open StoryDogs or use the planning sheet on a board. You are the scribe and timekeeper; children supply the ideas.

Start with a clear agreement

Say: “We’re making one story together. Everyone can offer ideas, and we’ll choose what fits. Ideas we don’t use can become another story.” Read the two questions at each stage separately.

Use this rhythm for each question

Give everyone 10 seconds to think or sketch, then a short partner whisper. Hear two or three ideas, including a new voice. Choose one and write a short answer in the children’s words. Read it back: “Have I got that right?”

Choose without a long debate

If two ideas both fit, take a quick vote. Combine ideas only when they make one clear event. If time is running out, choose and explain: “We’ll use this because it connects to our character’s wish.” A vote decides this story, not whose idea is best.

Keep the story connected

After UH-OH!, ask: “What happens because of that?” If an idea seems random, try: “How could that grow from our last event?” If it still doesn’t fit, park it: “Let’s save that for another story.” At SHOWDOWN / CLIMAX, ask what the character chooses to do.

Make room for every child

Let students pass, draw, point, or dictate. Offer a home-language rehearsal with a partner when useful. Invite quiet contributions without requiring a public performance: “Would you like me to read your idea?” Rotate who speaks and who records in pairs.

When energy or time runs out

Use one matching prompt card, or offer two possible directions and let children adapt them. Say: “We can use a small idea and improve it later.” If one child dominates: “Hold that thought. Let’s hear someone new.” Save the last two minutes to finish AFTER! / CHANGE and read the whole story.

Finish with something they made

Invite a title, read the story with expression, and name one specific success: “That first attempt caused the next problem.” For K–2, act or draw a moment. For older children, ask which choice changed the ending. Use the sharing guide for a longer celebration.